natural instinct to forage and he advocates for controlled feeding instead. However, for some like Chetan Kamble, founder of the citizens' group Chachak Dadar, the problem is urban order. He says pigeons at feeding stations pose risks to traffic, especially two-wheelers. Kamble also points to what he sees as "hypocrisy": a Jain temple near the Dadar *kabutarkhana* has installed nets to keep pigeons out, even as Jain groups insist the birds be fed in public spaces.

FAULT LINES TO THE FORE

The language-driven divides of Maharashtra's polity, especially in Mumbai and its surrounding areas, have made the pigeon-feeding controversy sharply polarising—pitting Marathi speakers against the Jain community. Relations between the two had already been strained in recent years over a range of issues: meat-eating Maharashtrians being denied housing in neighbourhoods dominated by vegetarian Gujaratis, Marwaris and Jains; the mushrooming of Jain-only gated complexes in former working-class Maharashtrian localities; and the shutting down or relocation of fish markets located near such buildings. The monk Nileshchandra Vijay had appealed to Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray to intervene. But Thackeray, for his part, sought action against those who continue feeding pigeons, asking the monk to adhere to the HC order.

After the Dadar *kabutarkhana* row, the nativist outfit Marathi Ekikaran Samiti (MES) organised a morcha of Maharashtrians and local residents in support of the ban. MES vice-president Pramod Parte questioned why a minor issue like a ban on pigeon-feeding had been given a religious colour by the Jains, alleging that the community's show of strength was directed against Marathis.

Analysts say pro-Marathi parties such as the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) and the MNS—despite their strong presence in Dadar and a history of physically attacking Hindi speakers—have been muted in the face of aggression from the wealthier Jains. "The established political parties are beholden to the Jains and cannot afford to hurt them. This has exposed the limitations of politics around Marathi," notes academician Deepak Pawar of the Marathi Abhyas Kendra. He says the growing assertion of Jains can be traced to the BJP's reign and "the power of numbers of North Indians, the resources of the Jains and the ideology of the RSS".

The issue also gave the Shiv Sena (UBT) a stick to beat the ruling Mahayuti with. Lok Sabha MP Anil Desai, whose constituency covers Dadar, accused the state government of indulging in vote-bank politics for electoral gains. But a party source attributes the Sena (UBT)'s lack of aggressive stance to the Jains' ability to vote en masse and tilt the balance. The MNS argues that the BJP is banking on a Jain and non-Maharashtrian consolidation to win the forthcoming BMC polls. The BJP, however, rejects the charge, with state spokesperson Keshav Upadhye insisting that Fadnavis will "evolve a solution that will strike a golden mean between the faith of the society and the health of the masses".

Environmentalists say that the easy availability of food and overfeeding have driven a sharp rise in the pigeon population, accompanied by a parallel surge in rodents that thrive on the leftover grain. Natural predators such as kites and cats have been unable to keep pace. The State of India's Birds 2023 report notes that the numbers of the rock pigeon (*Columba livia*) have increased by 158.47 per cent since 2000, effectively making it an invasive species. Each bird, estimates suggest, produces around 11.5 kg of droppings annually. The health risks apart, these droppings are also a hazard to Mumbai's heritage structures, a senior BMC official points out. They can often trigger chemical reactions, leaving stains on iconic monuments.

Kishor Rithe, director of the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS), stresses the importance of maintaining an ecological balance. The surge in pigeon numbers, he notes, has coincided with a decline in native bird species such as flycatchers. "In wildlife management, it is an established fact that the dominance of one species is dangerous to others," he explains, adding that science, not sentiment, should guide the debate on pigeon-feeding. Jay Shringarpure, an environmentalist who heads the MNS's environment wing, argues that illegal *kabutarkhanas* have fuelled the unchecked growth of pigeons. His campaign targets awareness rather than punishment. "If pigeons were not fed, they would follow their natural impulse to search for food and water," he says. Wildlife conservationist Kedar Gore calls it a problem without an amicable solution. "It is either *aar* or *paar* (this way or that way)," he says.

The bird itself is oblivious to all the chaos erupting around it, flocking around the feed left for them. It is humans who have to choose between faith and sanitation. ■

—with Sonali Acharjee

BAN ON PIGEON-FEEDING

FOR

"Science, not sentiment, should guide the debate on pigeon-feeding. The dominance of one species is dangerous to others"

Kishor Rithe, *Director, Bombay Natural History Society*

AGAINST

"Any ban on feeding would infringe on the fundamental rights of birds, who have their own niche in the ecosystem"

Atul Shah (Dadhi), *Trustee, Vardhaman Parivar, a Jain organisation*